

LN905 Everyday English Informal News and Media Vocabulary Exercises

Target Vocabulary

Verbs: to dig up, to leak, to spin, to break (a story), to bury (a story), to slam, to blast, to nail down, to sensationalize, to debunk

Nouns: scoop, tabloid, clickbait, soundbite, hype, buzz, dirt, insider, whistleblower, hack (journalist)

Adjectives/Expressions: hot off the press, trending, viral, under wraps, off the record, hard-hitting, biased, yellow journalism

Exercise 1: Definition Matching

Match each informal term with its correct definition:

1. scoop
2. clickbait
3. spin
4. leak
5. slam
6. dig up
7. soundbite
8. hype
9. viral
10. under wraps

Definitions: a) To present information in a way that favours a particular viewpoint b) Content designed to attract clicks through sensational headlines c) To criticize harshly in public d) A short, memorable quote from a longer interview or speech e) An exclusive news story published before competitors f) To spread rapidly across social media platforms g) To secretly reveal confidential information h) Excessive publicity or promotion i) To research and uncover hidden information j) Kept secret or confidential

Exercise 2: Gap Fill

Complete the sentences using the appropriate informal vocabulary from the word bank. You may need to change the form of the words.

Word Bank: break, bury, whistleblower, tabloid, debunk, nail down, trending, hack, off the record, hard-hitting

1. The journalist spent months trying to _____ the exact details of the corruption scandal.
2. That story has been _____ on social media all day – everyone's talking about it.

3. The _____ revealed serious safety violations at the nuclear plant.
 4. The newspaper decided to _____ the story about the mayor's personal life to avoid a lawsuit.
 5. She's known as a skilled political _____ who can get interviews with anyone.
 6. The reporter told me this information was strictly _____, so I can't publish it yet.
 7. The investigative team worked to _____ the conspiracy theory with solid evidence.
 8. Which news outlet managed to _____ the story about the celebrity wedding first?
 9. The documentary featured _____ interviews with former government officials.
 10. Don't believe everything you read in that _____; they're known for exaggerating stories.
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Exercise 3: Contextual Usage

Read the scenarios and choose the most appropriate informal expression for each situation. Explain your choice.

Scenario 1: A news website publishes an article with the headline "You Won't Believe What This Celebrity Did Next!" but the actual story is quite mundane.

- Options: a) yellow journalism b) clickbait c) hard-hitting journalism

Scenario 2: A politician's spokesperson carefully words a statement to make a scandal seem less serious than it actually is.

- Options: a) spinning the story b) breaking the story c) burying the story

Scenario 3: A journalist discovers important information about government corruption but is asked by their editor not to publish it due to political pressure.

- Options: a) the story goes viral b) the story is buried c) the story is sensationalized

Scenario 4: A news report spreads rapidly across Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram, with thousands of people sharing and commenting on it.

- Options: a) the story is under wraps b) the story goes viral c) the story is off the record

Scenario 5: A reporter spends weeks investigating a company's financial records and interviewing former employees to uncover evidence of fraud.

- Options: a) digging up dirt b) creating hype c) getting a soundbite
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Contextual Paragraphs – Read the following paragraphs and complete the gaps with one of the words or phrases from above

Paragraph 1: Breaking News in the Digital Age

When the story first broke on social media, it spread like wildfire across every platform imaginable. The initial ----- came from a relatively unknown blogger who had been digging up dirt on the pharmaceutical company for months. Within hours, major news outlets were scrambling to ----- the facts, but by then the story had already gone viral. The company's PR team immediately went into damage control mode, trying to ----- the narrative in their favour, but it was too late – the buzz around the scandal was already generating massive ----- . Traditional media found themselves playing catch-up to citizen journalists who had been tracking the story under wraps for weeks.

Paragraph 2: The Dark Side of Modern Journalism

The rise of clickbait culture has fundamentally changed how news is consumed and produced. Many outlets now prioritize trending topics over substantial reporting, often sensationalizing stories to generate more ----- and revenue. This shift toward yellow journalism has made it increasingly difficult for readers to distinguish between hard-hitting investigative pieces and ----- -style gossip. Meanwhile, genuine ----- who leak important information to the public often find their revelations buried beneath layers of celebrity drama and manufactured controversy. The pressure to ----- stories first sometimes leads journalists to publish unverified information, later having to debunk their own reports when the facts don't hold up.

Paragraph 3: Behind the Scenes of Political Reporting

Political journalism has become a high-stakes game where every ----- is analyzed and every comment made off the record is carefully guarded. Seasoned political ----- know that politicians and their staff are constantly trying to control the narrative, feeding selected information to friendly reporters while keeping damaging stories under wraps. When a major scandal erupts, rival news organizations will often slam each other's coverage, claiming ----- or inadequate fact-checking. The most successful political reporters are those who can build relationships with insiders, gaining access to exclusive information while maintaining their credibility. In this environment, the line between legitimate reporting and partisan ----- has become increasingly blurred.